NHMEC

Community Herbalist Diploma

Level II – Applied Studies

MODULE 8

Community Herb Gardens & Medicinal Landscapes

Module Overview

Community herb gardens are living classrooms.

They provide opportunities to teach herbal identification, sustainable gardening, stewardship, nutrition, pollinator conservation, and traditional plant knowledge. Whether planted at a church, school, library, community center, or neighborhood park, medicinal herb gardens become gathering places where people learn together while caring for God's creation.

Unlike private medicinal gardens, community herb gardens are designed with education in mind. Every pathway, plant label, demonstration bed, and harvesting area should encourage curiosity and responsible stewardship.

In this module, you will learn how to design, organize, plant, and maintain educational medicinal gardens that serve your community while preserving botanical diversity for future generations.

Module Objectives

Upon successful completion of this module, students will be able to:

• Explain the purpose of community herb gardens.

• Design an educational medicinal garden.

• Select appropriate medicinal plants for different climates.

• Plan seasonal planting schedules.

• Create pollinator-friendly landscapes.

• Develop educational garden signage.

• Organize community gardening projects.

• Encourage environmental stewardship through gardening.

Required Reading

Read the sections of the **Community Herbalist eGuide** relating to:

• Community Gardens

• Medicinal Plant Cultivation

• Stewardship

• Sustainable Gardening

• Educational Gardening

• Plant Conservation

As you read, identify ideas that could be incorporated into a public medicinal herb garden.

Learning Outcomes

By the end of this module, students should understand that a medicinal herb garden is more than a collection of plants—it is an educational resource that strengthens communities, preserves traditional herbal knowledge, and encourages responsible stewardship.

Instructor Lecture

Why Community Herb Gardens Matter

Medicinal herb gardens provide opportunities for people to reconnect with nature.

They teach:

Plant identification

Growing techniques

Seasonal harvesting

Pollinator conservation

Food production

Herbal preparations

Environmental stewardship

Community cooperation

Unlike books, gardens provide hands-on learning that engages all the senses.

Types of Community Herb Gardens

Community Herbalists may develop:

Church medicinal gardens

School teaching gardens

Library demonstration gardens

Senior center wellness gardens

Community center gardens

Hospital healing gardens

Children's sensory gardens

Pollinator gardens

Kitchen herb gardens

Raised-bed medicinal gardens

Container herb gardens

Each garden serves a unique educational purpose.

Planning Your Garden

Before planting, consider:

Sunlight

Water availability

Soil quality

Drainage

Accessibility

Walking paths

Maintenance

Parking

Educational space

Future expansion

Good planning prevents many future problems.

Choosing Medicinal Plants

Select herbs that are:

Easy to grow

Well adapted to your climate

Safe for educational settings

Useful for demonstrations

Visually attractive

Supportive of pollinators

Include a variety of:

Annuals

Perennials

Native medicinal plants

Culinary herbs

Aromatic herbs

Flowering herbs

Root herbs

Garden Design Principles

Create gardens that are easy to navigate.

Include:

Clearly marked pathways

Plant labels

Educational signs

Rest areas

Demonstration tables

Compost area

Rain barrel

Water access

Shade

Storage

A welcoming garden encourages learning.

Pollinator Gardens

Healthy medicinal gardens support healthy ecosystems.

Include plants that attract:

Honeybees

Native bees

Butterflies

Hummingbirds

Beneficial insects

Avoid practices that unnecessarily harm pollinator populations.

Pollinator conservation is an important responsibility of Community Herbalists.

Seasonal Garden Planning

Spring:

Soil preparation

Seed starting

Cool-season herbs

Summer:

Maintenance

Harvesting

Workshops

Fall:

Seed saving

Garden cleanup

Perennial planting

Winter:

Planning

Education

Equipment maintenance

Community Herbalists work with nature's seasons rather than against them.

Educational Garden Signage

Every community garden should educate visitors.

Signs may include:

Common name

Botanical name

Plant family

Medicinal parts

Historical uses

Pollinator information

Growing requirements

Interesting botanical facts

Educational signs encourage independent learning.

Community Garden Volunteers

Successful gardens depend upon teamwork.

Volunteers may assist with:

Planting

Weeding

Mulching

Watering

Harvesting

Teaching

Seed saving

Maintenance

Community events

Good leadership encourages long-term volunteer involvement.

Biblical Reflection

Psalm 24:1 (KJV)

"The earth is the LORD'S, and the fulness thereof; the world, and they that dwell therein."

Community herb gardens remind us that we are caretakers of God's creation. Every seed planted, every garden maintained, and every person taught is an opportunity to glorify God through faithful stewardship.

Vocabulary

Define:

Medicinal Garden

Pollinator Garden

Raised Bed

Companion Planting

Native Plant

Perennial

Annual

Composting

Seed Saving

Garden Stewardship

Reflection Questions

1. Why are community herb gardens valuable?
2. Which type of garden would best serve your community?
3. What challenges might a community garden face?

4. How do medicinal gardens support education?
5. Why should Community Herbalists encourage native plants?
6. How can children benefit from medicinal gardens?
7. What role do volunteers play in maintaining community gardens?

Practical Activity

Visit a Community Garden

Visit one of the following:

Community Garden

Botanical Garden

Church Garden

School Garden

Arboretum

Nature Center

Observe:

Garden layout

Accessibility

Educational signage

Plant diversity

Pollinator activity

Volunteer involvement

Write a two-page evaluation describing how the garden could be improved as an educational herbal garden.

Garden Design Exercise

Sketch a medicinal herb garden.

Include:

Entrance

Walking paths

Raised beds

Pollinator section

Teaching area

Composting area

Storage

Water source

Seating

Educational signs

Label all major features.

Assignment

Design a Community Medicinal Herb Garden

Develop a complete proposal.

Include:

Mission Statement

Target Audience

Garden Goals

Plant List (minimum 30 medicinal plants)

Garden Layout

Seasonal Planting Calendar

Volunteer Schedule

Maintenance Plan

Educational Signage

Workshop Ideas

Estimated Budget

Community Partnerships

Minimum Length:

10–12 pages.

Mini Quiz

1. The primary purpose of a community herb garden is to:

A. Produce commercial crops

B. Provide education and stewardship opportunities

C. Replace grocery stores

D. Grow ornamental plants only

2. Educational garden signs should include:

A. Only plant prices

B. Botanical and common names with educational information

C. Advertisements

D. Personal opinions

3. Pollinator gardens benefit:

A. Only butterflies

B. Bees, butterflies, birds, and beneficial insects

C. Only honeybees

D. Garden pests

4. Raised beds are helpful because they:

A. Eliminate watering

B. Improve accessibility and soil management

C. Prevent plant growth

D. Replace native soils completely

5. Community gardens are most successful when they include:

A. One gardener

B. Community volunteers and educational leadership

C. No planning

D. No maintenance

Answer Key

1. B
2. B
3. B
4. B
5. B

Module Project

Community Medicinal Garden Portfolio

Create a professional portfolio that includes:

• Master Garden Layout

• Planting Calendar

• Plant List (30 medicinal herbs)

• Botanical Labels

• Educational Sign Designs

• Pollinator Garden Plan

• Volunteer Handbook

• Garden Maintenance Schedule

• Harvest Guidelines

• Community Workshop Schedule

• Budget

• Photographs or Illustrations

This portfolio should be suitable for presentation to a church, school, library, community center, or nonprofit organization interested in developing an educational medicinal herb garden.

Community Herbal Journal

Record:

• Ten medicinal plants you would include in your community garden.

• Three pollinator-friendly species you want to grow.

• Two challenges you anticipate when managing a public garden.

• One goal for creating or participating in a community herb garden within the next five years.

Module Completion Checklist

☐ Required reading completed

☐ Vocabulary completed

☐ Reflection questions answered

☐ Community garden visited

☐ Garden sketch completed

☐ Garden proposal submitted

☐ Garden portfolio created

☐ Quiz passed (80% or higher)

☐ Herbal Journal updated

Looking Ahead

In **Module 9**, you will explore **Community Herbal First Aid**, learning how to assemble educational herbal first aid kits, organize wellness preparedness resources, discuss traditional topical herbal preparations, and educate communities about safe herbal first-aid practices while remaining within an appropriate educational scope.